FREE HOBBY STARTER KIT

Board Games We Own

For the grown-up · read this first, then hand over the tracker

Here is the funny truth about board-game night: the barrier isn't buying a better game, it's opening the box that's already in the closet. Most houses own more games than they play, often because one lost rulebook or one "read-the-rules" hour stands between everyone and the table. This hobby costs nothing but one evening of going through what you already own.

How to run the first shelf hunt

- **Empty the game shelf onto the table.** This counts as the activity itself. Kids will plan the whole afternoon in the first ten minutes.
- **Log what you find, not what you wish you had.** The inventory page wants the names, odd pieces, and honest verdicts ("never played", "great but we lost two tiles").
- **Fix one game and play it tonight.** Missing a die? Any substitute works — write the substitute rule right on the house-rules box on page 3. That repair is a memory in the making.
- **Pick the next game before tidying up.** Ending each session with "so next week we finally try…" makes the shelf feel like a plan.

> **Rules-shortcut:** look rules up online together, or make the simpler rule from the inside of the box official. House rules are allowed; they're not cheating if everyone agrees before the first turn.

The no-gear rule

The games, a pencil, and the printed pages are the whole kit. If you find a game missing too many pieces to save, don't toss it — its dice and cards can serve as replacements and its box becomes the log's home on the shelf.

Print page 2 (shelf inventory) and page 3 (game-night helper) once; copy them again when the shelf grows.

Shelf Inventory

One row per game you own. Be honest in the last two columns — they are the reason this page becomes useful later.

GAME NAME	PLAYERS	MINUTES TO PLAY	NOTHING MISSING?	WHEN WE LAST PLAYED	OUR HONEST VERDICT

Found in the shelf hunt

- Games with missing pieces:
- Games nobody remembers owning:
- Games worth playing again this week:

Fix-it list

Game	What it needs	What we'll use instead

> **Verdict vocabulary:** "played to death", "chore", "great with the right crowd", "needs a rules fix", "sleeping beauty" (never opened) are all valid entries. The shelf inventory should read like the family, not a store.

Game-Night Helper

This page is for one game night at a time. Photocopy it or fill the top box in pencil.

Before we start (all boxes, every time)

- ☐ Game picked (from the Shelf Inventory, ideally something honest)
- ☐ All pieces counted for every player's set
- ☐ Rules skimmed or agreed house rule settled
- ☐ Scoresheet and pencil on the table
- ☐ Snacks and drinks away from the board
- ☐ Nobody recites every rule first — learn as you go, ask mid-game

House rules (that everyone agreed to)

GAME	OUR RULE	WHY (ONE LINE)

Games we'd love to try next

- ☐ From a friend's house
- ☐ From a review or video
- ☐ From a game we already love, by the same maker

Checking a box doesn't mean buying — trade, borrow, or ask for a birthday first.

Game-night log

DATE	GAME	WINNER	MOOD 1–5

> **The closing ceremony:** at the end of the night, put the scoresheet for any close game straight into the game box, playing pieces that always escape into zip-lock bags, and update the Shelf Inventory's "when we last played" column. Sixty seconds now means a fun hunt next month.